

HDI Final Pitch

They say communication is the bedrock of every successful relationship. But communication only works when both parties speak the same language. In Nigeria today, we are over 200 million people - diverse, beautiful, and culturally rich, with over **500 languages** and **250 ethnic groups** - but also deeply **divided**.

This disunity is not surprising. It is the natural result of systemic neglect, ethnic fear, and a lack of sustained human connection. And while Nigeria already has institutions like the **National Orientation Agency (NOA)**, the **NYSC**, and the **Federal Character Principle**, the truth is:

They are only as effective as the tools they operate with.

Let's talk about NYSC: an incredible idea on paper, but what has it become? A bureaucratic program many young people endure, not embrace. A recent report from SBM Intelligence (2023) highlights how **youths now see NYSC as a mere formality**, with over **72% of respondents citing lack of value** in their experience. And the **Federal Character Principle**? Often reduced to paperwork, not partnership.

The **NOA**? It has the structure, it has the nationwide reach, but what it lacks is the **youth-centered engagement model** that the digital world requires.

So what if we changed the game? Not with another lecture. But with a **policy that meets Nigerians where they are**; in their phones, their radios, their marketplaces, and their daily lives.

We're introducing: **HDI: the Harmony in Diversity Initiative**

A grassroots, tech-driven, youth-led policy that doesn't ask for unity but builds it.

HDI runs on five core pillars:

1. **Unity Engagement Missions**; Young people complete cultural tasks and earn recognition. Not for clout, but for change.
2. **Language Exchange Modules**; I remember one day I greeted someone in Yoruba. He didn't answer. Out of curiosity, I greeted again and he responded in Hausa. I recognized a few phrases, so I replied with "Sannu." He smiled. That was it. That was the extent of our communication. He was open to connecting, but I couldn't reciprocate. Now imagine if we had access to tools that allowed us to casually pick up each other's languages.

Today, people use **Duolingo** to learn French, not because they're moving to Paris, but because their friend speaks French. Or because their **crush** is learning Spanish and they want to send

them XP boosts. It's fun. It's social. And that's exactly what we're bringing into HDI; fun, culturally-rich, **purposeful learning** that goes beyond "hello."

In fact, a recent study by Duolingo showed that learners were **more likely to persist** when they had **social motivators**, not just academic goals. It's not about perfection, it's about connection.

3. **Community Projects with Cross-Ethnic Teams**; Youths are grouped across ethnic lines and given missions from murals to cleanups. These tasks don't just build their CVs - they build cross-cultural respect.
4. **Youth Policy Co-creation Platform**; Like Taiwan's civic-tech model, young people get to **suggest policies**, **vote on unity campaigns**, and **build awareness initiatives** themselves. The government doesn't talk at them. It listens to them.
5. **The Unity App** - A light, clean mobile platform where all these happen: story uploads, challenge completions, rewards, group missions, and progress tracking.

But this is not just for the educated elite.

In my home, my mom listens to the radio daily. She looks forward to specific programs. That's why we're designing **HDI to include older generations** through:

- **Local language radio programs**
- **TV slots on popular channels**
- **Storytelling segments from different tribes**

With the **NOA as our distribution partner**, HDI leverages their infrastructure to carry unity far beyond apps.

Let's talk about **Caller Tunes**.

Today, people have songs that reflect pain, lust, or vanity. What if instead, they heard:

"You are more than your tribe - you are Nigeria." "A handshake across cultures is stronger than a thousand fists within one." "Unity doesn't erase differences. It harmonizes it."

HDI uses caller tunes not for vibes - but for **transformation**.

Let's not forget: unity is **not built in one event**. It is built in **daily, visible, and rewarding action**.

HDI fits into NYSC as an enhancement - Corps members get grouped in culturally diverse teams. They complete missions and earn points. At the end of each season, the top teams are rewarded **publicly and handsomely**, both online and offline.

Even **those without smartphones** are not left behind. HDI introduces:

- **Unity Circles** in local areas (church youth, garage riders, okada parks)
- **Story cards** and physical unity missions
- **Ambassadors** from every demographic

So I ask you:

What if national unity wasn't a memory we talked about, but a mission we lived daily?

What if the Fulani girl in Gombe and the Igbo boy in Nsukka were not debating politics, but swapping proverbs and peace stories?

What if a tech-enhanced civic system could make that happen?

That's the HDI.

That's the future.

That's what we came to build.

Thank you.